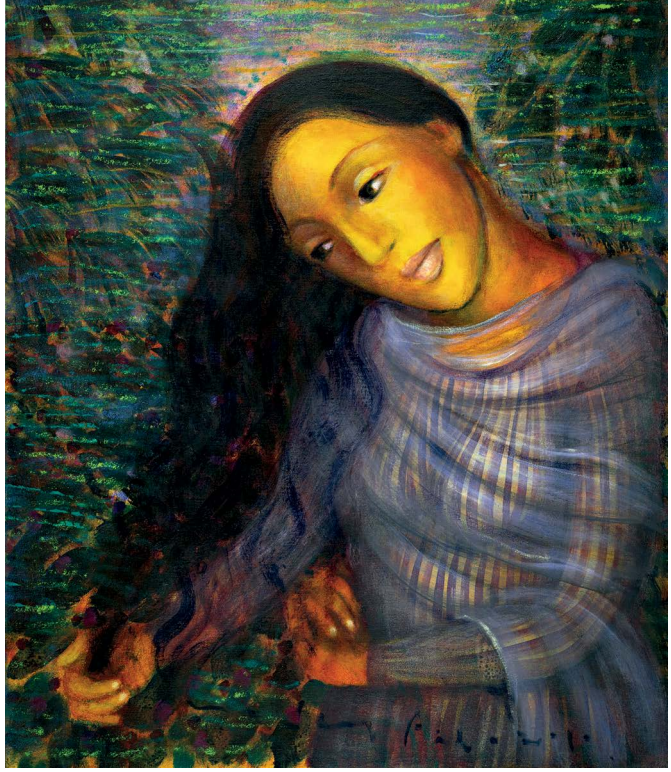
ART

HYBRID FORMS

ARTFUL WONDERS
(clockwise from right) 'It is Raining Outside', 2010; 'Halley's Comet II', 1986; 'Hathyogini-Kali 1', 2019-22; 'Kamdhenu', 1995







***Mythic Femininities* at DAG Delhi brings together a well-chosen cross-section of the late GOGI SAROJ PAL's large body of work**

During one of the last recorded interviews with the artist Gogi Saroj Pal (1945-2024), who passed away in January, she talks at length about her *Kamdhenu* series of paintings, created between 1989 and 1998. These works feature a hybrid woman-cow figure in a variety of situations, reflecting the constrictive roles into which society forces women, not to mention the constant extraction of domestic and emotional labour (akin to the relentless milking of a cow). The interview (by Ankan Kazi) has been published in the accompanying catalogue for *Mythic Femininities*, the Gogi Saroj Pal retrospective at Delhi's DAG that shall run till May 25. In it, Pal says, "People in our culture make constant comparisons of human behaviour with animals. Especially for women—if someone is well-behaved, she is said to be like a cow. But a cow is not asked about its own will or wishes, is it? The *Kamdhenu* works reflect this directly."

Mythic Femininities presents the viewer with a well-chosen cross-section of Pal's large body of work—there's something here from practically every major phase of her career, including her earliest art school exercises in draughtsmanship. Her women are sometimes Kamdhenu, sometimes the 'Nayika' (literally, 'female protagonist' in Hindi), sometimes the limb-contorting, freedom-loving 'Hathyogini'. In all of these avatars, women are challenging the things they are told to say or do by society—sometimes, the subversion is direct (the Nayikas are sensual and even coquettish at first glance). Sometimes, it's a more subtle expression, like 'Mandi' (1983, oil on canvas) which reproduces a stereotypical male gaze at a woman with a sphinx-like demeanour, eyes shining with prehistoric wisdom.

Women-animal hybrids also recur in her works, including the *Dancing Horse* and *Kinnari* series. The latter is informed by both Hindu and Buddhist mythologies. During the artist's childhood in Kangra, she witnessed the migration of Buddhist monks to Dharamshala in the late 1950s. She later shot a few documentaries on their 'displaced lives'—the painting series *Young Monks* is a testament to the role migration and displacement played throughout her artistic career.



Although Pal's mastery over the human (and human-animal) figures was undisputed, her unique talents and distinctive vision were also readily apparent in landscapes and other paintings sans humans. Perhaps the most famous among these, 'Mr Singh's Residence' (1984, oil and acrylic on canvas), is informed by the anti-Sikh pogrom of 1984. This painting shows an empty house whose angles and contours seem to be folding in on themselves, like M.C. Escher's never-ending staircases.

The catalogue for *Mythic Femininities* includes an essay by the writer, historian and publisher Urvashi Butalia, written just weeks before the artist's demise. At one point in this essay, Pal claims she saw her body mostly as a vessel for creativity, especially when the inspiration struck her. With her demise, we have lost one of our tallest artists. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha